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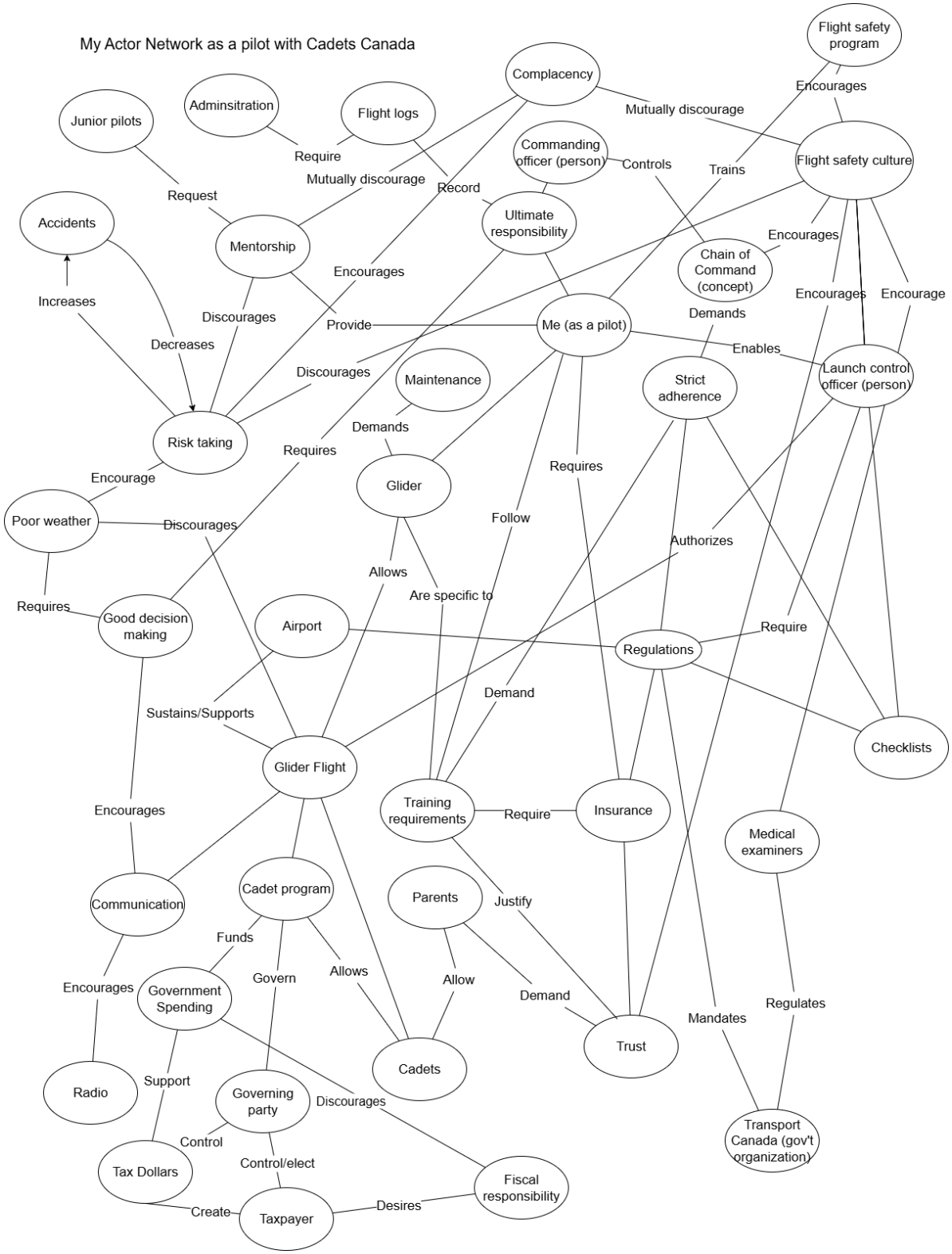
Guiding question: How has being a glider pilot in the cadet program shaped my view of responsibility?



One particularly stable ordering of the network is our equipment, most notably the aircraft. They are locked into their roles in allowing glider flights because of the large capital investment made by the taxpayer into purchasing the equipment. It would be prohibitively expensive and politically unfavourable for the government to spend the taxpayer's dollars to purchase a new fleet of aircraft, and to also retrain the hundreds of pilots nationally. This system is locked in because there isn't a good reason to overhaul the equipment; the flight safety program and maintenance have done a really quality job to enable the flying operation to continue. It would take a catastrophic incident for trust in the cadet program to be degraded enough to consider modernizing the fleet, and the continued good pilot decision making and safety standards have prevented that from happening. This leads to the punctualisation of the equipment as a black box that enables the flights to happen, leading to stability as the flying operation is very similar on a day to day basis. Having the same equipment for the past five decades ensures that everything else evolves pretty slowly, as there isn't really much to change. Very little thought happens on a day to day basis on why we use these particular pieces of equipment. I do have a personal preference of flying with newer aircraft, as that would also provide a better experience for the cadet who's taking the glider flight. Knowing that there is nothing realistically that can be done about this though, given the heavy inertia of the system, masks my (and most other staff's) preferences of flying better aircraft. The system has so much power because it's so expensive to change it, especially because it has worked for a very long time.

In the past year, I experienced a significant change in my position within the network when I was quasi-promoted from cadet pilot to staff pilot. As a cadet, I still had some responsibility, particularly when acting as a pilot, but a significant amount of responsibility was externalized to staff and instructors, and my actions were framed as training exercises under supervision. As a staff member, my role was redefined into the responsibility-carrying role that I was sheltered under as a cadet. This also came with a significant amount of depunctualisation, as staff have a greater awareness of the regulations and authorizations required to send a glider flight. As staff, I was encouraged and enabled to act as a mentor to the new cadet pilots, and especially maintain the flight safety culture. This change demonstrates how responsibility is not an internal trait but something produced and redistributed by the network. My promotion added new relations, or swapped my position in some human-human relations. By being redefined as staff, I shouldered more responsibility and became a mentor to reproduce norms. This shows how my view of responsibility has shifted; it was contingent on how the network configured my role. I also became significantly more aware of the wider program as a whole and how different actors, especially some that seemed distant, play important roles in keeping the flights going. For example, it is important that we provide a sense of flight safety, because otherwise the parents (who we don't see at the airport and are thus very distant) will lose trust and won't allow their kids to go flying. As a lowly cadet pilot, the interactions at the outskirts of the actor network were not at the forefront of any thought, but having had my role changed required a new level of awareness of how the power flowed through different actors, and how we had to balance that to keep a safe and efficient operation.

Weather is a nonhuman actor that exerts a lot of power over glider operations. The gliders themselves are relatively lightweight and fragile, meaning we can only fly in good weather. Moderate winds or rain can refuse flight entirely, overriding my personal desire to continue flying. Despite my instinctive resistance, weather's influence is institutionalized in regulations that have been ingrained in me to make safe decisions. Interestingly enough, the power that weather exerts is pretty indirect. I have not personally crashed nor flown in horrible weather. The rules and regulations created and enforced by Transport Canada and the cadet program are derived from others' acci-

dents and rigourous engineering standards. Weather therefore exerts power not through my own firsthand experience but through its codification in documents and practices. The launch control officer is required to check the weather and make decisive calls, either allowing or refusing flight. Responsibility is redistributed through these relations. Parents' trust in the cadet program, as well as the organization's reputation, depend on visible adherence to safe weather protocol. To resist the refusal power of weather would be exposing myself to consequences, not from weather, but from Transport Canada and the cadet program, who are looking to protect their interests by maintaining trust and an image of safety. The powers to be do recognize that weather's influence can wane through complacency. Accidents have a negatively reinforcing relationship with risk taking; without accidents to remind pilots of the power of weather, complacency can set in and increase risk taking. Instead of increasing the power of weather via accidents that would harm people, weather's power is increased through recurrent training with the flight safety program to limit risk taking. Weather illustrates how a nonhuman actor can shape responsibility, even if it doesn't directly stop flights. It exerts power through human and institutional actors; therefore my responsibility is not simply personal judgment but the culmination of the judgement of other actors in the network in response to events that I personally didn't witness.